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## The Hero of Phirn

Once upon a time, there existed a world unlike any other. One where fantasy and modern science worked together in tandem. However, our story takes place in a more fantastical setting, a mythical village located in the center of a mystical forest in the roots of a magic tree. That tree's name was Phirn: The Tree of Gifts, long ago this tree was created by the goddess of nature long before the beginning of man. She bestowed it with the magical sap that could be used to heal the sick and make the weak powerful. But, knowing that this power could be used for evil she created a new form of life to protect the tree. These magical spirits were called Frayer, a race of small, furry creatures that not only guarded the tree but, took care of it. Frayer's can also use magic like other spirits however, only a select few are granted the privilege of being on the Magic Council. Those on the council had the most important job of all, maintaining the force field that protected the tree from outside interference. These beings were crafted to spend their entire existence to protecting Phirn, meaning these creatures never left the sanctuary of the village. That was the truth until an event occurred that forced one special Frayer out of his home in order to save it. That Frayer is our hero Scout; Scout was born unlike the other for he was born without arms. When he emerged from the roots during the Harvest, an event that marked the beginning of new life in which newborn Frayers would emerge out of the trees roots to begin life, the other Frayers looked at him in awe and terror. In their entire existence not one Frayer had emerged with a flaw that stood unbroken until that fate full day. Scout was taken before the council to discuss what to do with him, some suggested to send him to rot as the guard that sat outside the field, which was the lowest ranking job given to a Frayer, but one sorcerer objected and suggested that she take him in. That spell caster was Misty Wistmith, the kindest and wisest in the entire council. She took Scout in, gave him his name, and gifted him with a power of his very own. Not only did she give him his very own arms but, the ability to detach them and move them, plus other objects, without touching them. Equipped with these new gifts, Scout devoted himself to being Wistmith's assistant and promised to do the best he possibly could. He lived up to his promise, Scout did whatever Wistmith needed him to do. However, life was not easy for him because the other Frayers saw him as an outcast and would constantly remind him of that fact whenever they got the chance to. Scout's confidence suffered because of it causing him to become anxious and not have faith in himself. Still, he continued to work for Wistmith learning a variety of things along the way, such as magic and its history. Life was simple, every Frayer was satisfied with their roll and Scout believed life would stay like this forever. But then again, none of them could have possibly imagined their entire existence to be threatened in the span of a day.

The day started off normal, Scout woke up early to prepare breakfast for Wistmith and himself. He made the usual, oatmeal with fresh fruit and tea, today he had made some chamomile tea the aroma of which filled the air.

“Mm-, smells wonderful.” Said Wistmith as she walked into the dining room. Scout gave her a small smile and began to serve her before serving himself. After cleaning up, Scout and Wistmith went on their daily stroll thru the town. They did this because it was Wistmith’s job to make sure everyone was doing their part in keeping the tree safe. As they were talking to the head farmer, who took care of the food supply, they heard a shriek. Then, the guard who watched the barrier came running and screaming.

“Monster! Monster!” cried the guard as he ran towards the council hall. Panic soon ensued, Frayers were running all around some even barricading themselves in buildings. While this was going on members of the magic council were running towards the field instead of away from it including Scout and Wistmith. When they all arrived they saw something quite shocking, a man in a mask was standing just outside the barrier.

“It can’t be.” Cried one of the council members in horror. For you see the council knew that man, and a long time ago Wistmith had told Scout about him as well. The man’s name was Xander Zythleth, a bounty hunter who works for the most powerful witch doctor in existence Alphys Dekar. She was once part of the most powerful groups ever to walk the planet, The Eternals, an evil force lead by the great Ogden Dovokaazonok. Ogden was once the prince of the dragon kingdom, but when denied his right to the throne, went insane and hungry for power. During his conquest, he meant four others who shared the same lust for power as he did. So, they joined forces in order to bring the world to its knees. However, after Ogden was defeated by Roswell and his four pillars, the group split up and was only occasionally seen. But now stood before the village of Phirn was a threat, one that had not been seen in years. Soon after the entire council had gathered, Xander made a move and began to pull what looked like a charm from out of his long coat. The council stood at the ready but, they did not make a move, at least not until they knew exactly what they were up against. Just then, he placed the amulet right against the field and began to chant something. The council finally made their move as well and began to chant a spell of their own in order to strengthen the barrier from Xander’s attack. But the effort was wasted, after completing his chant a hole had been made in the field, allowing him just enough space to walk through. The magic council tried, in vain, to hold him back but their spells seemed to nearly bounce off him. And by that time, it was too late, he had reached the tree. Every Frayer in the village looked out in pure terror at this sight, their sole purpose was to protect the tree and it had just been invaded by an evil unlike any other. The magic council retreated to the Great Hall in order to discuss what to do next. Every council member was summoned, including Wistmith, meaning Scout came along as well despite not being invited. Frayers were already discussing by themselves when they arrived and sat down. Then a tall Frayer with a beard and ash brown fur walked to the front of a podium.

“Alright everyone settles down now, the discussion is about to begin!” he asserted in a deep voice. The hall instantly became quiet, and they all stared at him waiting for him to speak again. That Frayer was the head of the council, known as Smokey Oaks, and one of the most powerful magic users in the hall.

“I’m sure I don’t need to explain the situation,” he stated, “What has occurred in the last hour has been most upsetting, but we need to figure out how to get this brute out of our sacred home!”

“We should use a curse to turn him into a flea!” cried one Frayer in a light purple robe.

“No way! Let’s set him a flame instead!” interjected another in a violet robe.

“Order, Order!” yelled Smokey as he banged a gavel, “Can we please get a smart idea!” he sighed.

“We should get some help.” Replied Wistmith rather calmly. Everyone turned to her in surprise, even Smokey looked shocked.

“What exactly do you mean Misty?” Smokey inquired

“I Mean- We should get help from the Druids of Etheria Keep.” Answered Wistmith. The entire hall went quiet, no Frayer had ever been outside the village so this suggestion of getting outside help was mind boggling.

“Who do you expect to go on a journey like this?” Smokey asked.

“Anyone who is willing to volunteer,” she replied, “So, is anyone willing to?” Her question was meant with silence, not a soul spoke up, but then-

“Why don’t you have your assistant take the journey!” yelled someone from the booths. Others began to agree with him, causing Scout to become anxious.

“That’s a good idea,” declared Smokey, “Let’s have your little Scout complete this mission.” Scout was applauded, first they treat him like nothing but when they need something now, they take notice.

“C’m on Scout what do you say?” asked another Frayer sarcastically.

“Um, Well I don’t-” stuttered Scout, his face was now a bright red and he was doing his best to held back tears. Wistmith tried to comfort him, the other Frayers giggled and muttered insults.

“Order, Order.” Objected Smokey, “Misty, your idea is all well and good but, there is no way any one of us could make the trip that far.”

“I disagree.” She responded bitterly.

“C’m on even your little assistant couldn’t agree with your plan.” He sneered.

“I didn’t say that!” cried Scout furiously, this shocked everyone including Wistmith.

“So, you do agree and are willing to go?” he pried.

“I stand by here idea, but I’m not the right person for the job.” Scout replied bluntly.

“Oh? Of course, who was I kidding, a burden like you could never do something like this.” Sneered Smokey. Scout was appalled, even the head of the council was mocking him. But Scout said something that flipped this whole argument on its head.

“Fine then! I will make the journey and prove to you I’m not just a burden!” he snarled. The entire hall fell silent, even Wistmith has never seen Scout so angry he is usually very reserved.

“Fine then its settled meeting adjourned!” Smokey replied angrily. When Scout and Wistmith arrived home, Scout was in a state of shock. Why on earth did he agree to do something like this? But still he said he would do it, so he began to pack for the journey ahead. He packed essentials; food, water, map, etc. Wistmith also lent Scout a hand in getting ready for the journey.

“Here, you should take this with you.” She handed him what looked like a gem encased in a glass sphere. “It should help you later into the forest.”

“Thank you,” he looked at her solemnly, “Sorry for losing my temper back there, I’m not sure what came over me.” He was clearly embarrassed and was fidgeting with the straps of his pack.

“Oh, there is no need to worry about that,” she giggled, “I’m actually glad you agreed to do this, I trust you more than any member of the castle to do this.” Scout was obviously flattered and promised to make her proud. They both walked to the edge to the barrier, said their goodbyes and gave each other a big hug. Scout looked out at the unknown before him, then let out a sigh before taking his first few steps out of the village.

He had been walking for only a few hours, but it was already starting to get dark. Deciding to continue walking in the dark, exposed was a bad idea he instead set up a small camp near the base of a large oak tree. After making his small shelter, Scout reached into his pack and pulled out a bag of trail mix made by the village shop keep. He was finally winding down from his adrenaline high when he heard a rustle from a near by bush. Then suddenly, a small, grey creature jumped out of the foliage. From what Scout could make out, the creature looked like a reptile, but it had what looked like bug legs. Before he could truly make it out the creature lunged at him, he barely managed to get out of the way. The shelter was destroyed, and the mix was being devoured by the creature. Scout thought it was preoccupied so he tried to sneak away, then it turned to him, so he stood perfectly still. Suddenly it came barreling towards him, striking at Scout with its beak like mouth. Scout managed to evade this onslaught, but he knew he couldn’t do this forever he need to think of a way to get rid of it. He thought of maybe using his powers, unfortunately he needs to contrate to do that and he couldn’t evade at the same time. Just then he had an idea, he moved close to a nearby bramble bush far from the creature. And, just as planned, the creature ran towards Scout a full speed. Scout was careful however, he began to contrate while still being mindful of the its position. The creature was drawing nearer, but before

it could nab Scout, he used his ability to fling it into the bush. He waited a few seconds to make sure that it was gone, then proceeded back to where the camp once stood to gather his things. By this point he was completely tired, and it was already pitch-black out. Now knowing that sleeping out in the open was a no go, he decided to dig himself a little den then cover it in some leaves so that he was extra safe.

In the morning, Scout's back was a little sore, but he didn't care, at least he was still alive. He took a quick look at his compass and map, then went on his way deeper into the forest. Being alone in the forest gave him a lot of time to think, he mostly thought about what was happening back at home. He supposed it was nothing good and hoped that he could do something to about that Xander. Then, his mind went to Wistmith, he missed her dearly and had trouble getting the thought of her being a danger out of her head. But he knew she could handle herself, so he shouldn't need to worry to much. A few days went on like this, thinking about home and what awaited him further down the road. Then on the fourth day something unexpected happened, he came up onto a fork in the road. Scout at first didn't bat an eye, then he checked the map and the fork was not indicated on it. That's when all his anxieties came rushing back into the forefront of his thoughts. He frantically checked the map multiple times hoping he would at least find something. Finally, he saw that each of the paths were named on the map. He let out a sigh, then read both names. One was called Mythic Meadow, which looked like a large clearing in the middle of the woods. The other was Poachers Pass, an area of the forest full of traps, thieves and nothing but danger. Scout considered the first path but saw that the pass was way faster, so, hesitantly, he went down Poachers Pass. He made sure to be extremely careful and to keep a watchful eye for any traps. Everything was, once again, going well until he heard a growling sound. At first, he ducked for cover, but after a few minutes realized the sound was not coming his way. Scout was about to run away but hesitated when he noticed the growling sounded more like a pained screech. So instead of running away, he went towards the sound. When he arrived, Scout came upon an odd scene, a large manecore ensnared in a gigantic trap that wrapped around its entire body. At first Scout was scared, but after watching it thrash around a bit, he felt sympathetic. So, in a risky move he approached the creature, making sure to ease in slowly.

"Um Hello." He said timidly. The beast stops thrashing for a second to get a good look at Scout.

"I just want to help you, so would you mind not attacking me when I do." After he said that, he began focusing in order to move the trap. It took a lot of effort, but he did eventually manage to get him loose. The beast stepped forward, allowing the way for Scout to close the trap safely.

"Thank you, kind sir," roared the manecore respectfully, "I am truly in your debt." He bowed. Scout was speechless and replied by gawking up at him.

"Uh hello?" questioned the beast, "Are you okay?"

"Oh? OH! Sorry I've just never seen a creature like you before." He giggled awkwardly.

"Ha-ha, I see well I still wish to repay you in some way." He answered with a grin revealing large jagged teeth.

“There is no ne- “he was about to responded with a no when he remembered he did need something. “Actually, do you mind flying me to Etheria Keep, if you don’t mind.” He asked.

“Of course, hop on and I’ll take you right there.” He said with a grin. Then, Scout hopped onto his back and held on tight as he began to take off. The view from above the trees was breathtaking, he had never seen anything from this high up before.

“Amazing isn’t it.” Said the creature while flying.

“It is.” He replied astonished.

“So, what is the name of my savior?” he asked with a bit of sarcasm.

“The name is Scout, and what about you?” Scout asked in reply.

“I am Yorick, it is an absolute pleasure.” They continued the chat for the rest of the trip, which took about two days, that also included the rest they had to take. Scout learned a lot about Yorick on this trip, the main thing was that he had a wife and a son. Apparently, he was hunting for food for his pregnant wife when he got trapped. Scout told Yorick about his life and what had occurred in his village.

“It’s very noble of you to take this journey all by yourself.” Yorick inquired.

“Uh, not really I mostly did it because I was made.” He remarked, this caused both to laugh. When they finally made it to their destination, they said their goodbyes and promised to one day meet again.

The keep was very large and full of people, also it looked more like a marketplace than what Scout was expecting. He strolled in, looking around at all the different stands. Some where food stands, a vast majority was items. But what he did not see was the Druids that he came all this way for. He tried to ask some people; however, no one could understand him. So, he searched for some sort of directory or something of the sort to figure out where they were. Eventually he came to a statue with Druid-esque figures, under it was a plaque with some information. It read, long ago this keep was once inhabited by Druids who studied magic and was one with the goddess, but due to unknown circumstances they have since left the keep. This news shocked Scout, how could Wistmith not know, how could he be such an idiot. In defeat, he sat at the base of the statue looking visually upset.

“Are you alright?” asked a female voice in concern. Scout looked up to see a woman wearing a large sweater.

“I’m having a day.” He replied in a ticked off tone.

“I get that,” she giggled, “So what exactly happened?” Scout explained everything to her and how his whole quest was for nothing.

“That’s rough, but why didn’t you use your magic to attack the man yourself?” she asked innocently. Scout thought for a moment before saying.

“I don’t have the power to take him on by himself.” He supposed bluntly.

“Well you could at least could’ve scared him off.” She acknowledged. Again, he thought and knew she was right, why couldn’t he have done that. After all, he did manage to make it all the way to the keep.

“You do have a point, but by the time I get back it will be far too late.” He sighed. Just then, a glow appeared from the inside of his bag. He opened it to find that the charm given to him by Wistmith was glowing. Before he had the chance to process, he was teleported to the front of the village. He thought about questioning it but pushed it away and made a mad dash towards the tree.

He managed to sneak into the tree, inside he saw Xander filling up what looked like a barrel with the essence of the tree. Scout made his way up to a ledge in the tree and began to concentrate. Then both the barrel and the fountain began to shake, soon the barrel burst open. The contents of both the barrel and the fountain swirled together to form a figure. Xander stumbled back, utterly confused by the scene that was unfolding before him. The form revealed teeth made from goo along with long claws. As it stared at Xander, he tried to pull something out of his coat, but was knocked down by the creature before he could fully pull it out. He smashed against the wall and a few charms fell out of his coat as well. The creature let out a gurgle sound, Xander stood up, then he ran away far from the tree and the village. After Scout put all the goo back in the fountain, he left the tree and saw that a crowd had formed. As soon as he stepped out the crowd cheered and showered him in praise. At first, he was quite embarrassed, when he suddenly felt a hand on his shoulder. He turned to see Wistmith grinning wide at him, he immediately hugged her with tears in his eyes.

“Good job kiddo.” She said while patting him on the head. Scout was so happy to see her that he almost completely forgot about the crowd. But then he heard another familiar voice.

“I’m sorry I doubted you Scout.” Admitted Smokey with a smile. Scout looked at him, he was holding out his hand, but instead of shaking it Scout hugged him as well. Smokey was surprised but accepted it. When the whole ordeal was over, Scout was not only granted a spot on the council but was given the title of Hero. Scout’s life had completely changed, he was no longer an outcast he was their savior. Though he couldn’t take all the credit, he had Yorick and that woman to thank. But for now, he was satisfied going back to having his village peaceful once more.